

Picking the Rights Fight

Buying a computer and the assorted peripherals is quite an expensive affair. If you have owned a computer for any length of time, you would be acutely aware of how far computers are from painless, 'install it, forget it' consumer electronics. There are always issues with component failures or upgrades due, and for those there is the inevitable interaction with your local dealer who will tell you that the replacement will be available in 2 weeks time. If you get him to talk to you, that is.

Try taking it upon yourself to pursue the matter with the company, and you end up talking to some call centre executive who can only answer questions that are on his or her list, and will forward your matter to the company "soon". Call centres too don't always have their act together, so no surprises if a "system failure" means you will have to wait another 3-4 days just to have a technician give your once-proud PC a look-see.

Real experiences with major brands reflect this sad truth. When was the last time you had a quick and satisfactory response from the company you paid in full for a 17-inch monitor?

The monopoly model that the cable broadband vendors enjoy almost everywhere across the country means that you either stick to your trusty modem and freedom to choose an ISP that gives you what you want, or put up with whatever your local cable guy can manage. With lower up-front costs, low barriers to switch providers and plenty of choice in every city, cell phone customer service levels are consistently higher than any other service company.

Once a high value purchase has been made, the vendor has effectively taken advantage of whatever value it can offer. Long term purchases such as monitors, hard-disks, motherboards, etc., have no recurring value and poor customer support cannot cause any financial consequences in the short-term. Very few consumers have the leisure to actually take a company to court, and ensure their problem is redressed.

Some things never change. Or do they?

Please voice your opinion in our reader poll this month.



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